

Imperial DoLS GTA Allocator Guide for PhD Students

Overview

The GTA Allocator helps match PhD students to practical demonstrating sessions. You can view available practicals, submit your preferences, and check your allocations.

Website: https://tonysouthall.github.io/GTA_allocator/

How It Works

1. **Browse** available practicals and their requirements
2. **Rank** the practicals you'd like to demonstrate, in order of preference
3. **Submit** your preferences before the deadline
4. **Check** your allocations once the DPS has run the allocation
5. **Confirm** or decline allocation(s) using the Accept and Decline buttons in your email
6. **Receive** automatic email reminders before your practicals
7. **Rate** your GTA experience after each practical to help us improve

Commitment: Sign Up = Show Up

If you sign up and are allocated to a practical, you are expected to attend.

If you cannot attend without a very good reason, your priority for future allocations may be reduced.

If you need to withdraw after being allocated, contact the DPS as soon as possible so a reserve can be allocated/found.

Submitting Your Preferences

Step 1: Enter Your Details

- Your Name
- Imperial Email - Use your @imperial.ac.uk email (this is where reminders will be sent)

Step 2: Select Your Areas of Expertise

Tick all areas that apply to you. This helps match you to practicals where your skills are most useful.

Step 3: Confirm Your Department

Only PhD students registered in the Department of Life Sciences (DoLS) are eligible to GTA for departmental practicals. Please confirm your department when submitting your preferences.

Step 4: Rank Your Preferred Practicals

- Click on a practical to add it to your preferences
- The order you click determines your ranking (1st choice, 2nd choice, etc.)
- Click again to remove a practical from your list
- Your current ranking is displayed below the practical list



Tips for ranking:

- ✓ Rank as many practicals as you're willing to do
- ✓ Put your most preferred practical first
- ✓ Consider the dates — make sure you're available!
- ✓ Check the expertise tags — you'll enjoy practicals that match your skills
- ✓ Click the  View Handbook link to learn more about what's involved
- ✓ Read the handbook before your practical — this is expected of all GTAs

Step 5: Submit

Click "Submit Preferences" to send your choices. You'll see a confirmation message.

Note: If you need to change your preferences after submitting, contact the DPS.

Understanding the Practical Listings

Information	What it means
Practical Name	The name/title of the practical session
Course Code	The module code (you'll need this for pay claims)
Date	When the practical takes place
Time	The advertised start and end time(s), and the total session length in hours
Slots	Number of GTAs needed
Deadline	Submit your preferences before this date
 View Handbook	Link to practical materials. READ THIS before your practical — it is expected of all GTAs.

Before Your Practical: Read the Handbook



Read the Handbook Before Your Practical

Every practical listing includes a link to a handbook. You are expected to read this before attending. The handbook covers what you need to know to demonstrate effectively: the practical content, safety information, and what students will be doing.

If no handbook is available, contact the course convenor in advance to ask what preparation is needed.

GTA Training

All GTAs are expected to complete the GTA training programme.

Training is coordinated by [Anita Hall \(anita.hall@imperial.ac.uk\)](mailto:anita.hall@imperial.ac.uk) and covers:

- What is expected of you as a demonstrator
- How to support students effectively in a practical setting



Keep up to date with training

Training sessions are scheduled at the start of term. Check communications from the DPS for dates. If you are unsure whether you have completed the required training, contact the DPS.

Checking Your Allocations

1. Go to the GTA Allocator website
2. Scroll down to "Check Your Allocations"
3. Enter your Imperial email address
4. Your allocated practicals will be displayed

Email Reminders

You'll automatically receive email reminders for your allocated practicals:

- 7 days before - Advance notice to prepare (use this time to read the handbook!)
- 1 day before - Final reminder

Reminders include the practical name, date, course code for your pay claim, and a link to the handbook if available.

Important: if you receive a 7-day or 1-day reminder and you are no longer able to GTA for that practical, you must let the DPS know as soon as possible so a reserve can be arranged.

Casual Payroll Registration

You must be registered with the casual payroll team to be paid for GTA work. Registration must be renewed every 51 weeks. If you're unsure of your registration status, contact the casual payroll team before your practical.

Pay for Prepwork

You are not paid for time spent preparing for a practical unless you have agreed this in advance with the course convenor. If you expect to need paid prep time beyond reading the handbook, discuss and agree this with the convenor before the practical.

Pay for Actual Hours Worked

Each practical listing shows advertised Session Times (Morning, Afternoon, or both) and the total advertised hours. You are paid for the hours you actually work, not the advertised hours — if a practical finishes earlier than advertised, your pay will reflect the actual time worked.

Summative Marking

GTA's should not carry out summative marking. Your role is to support students during the practical; summative assessment of student work remains the responsibility of academic staff. If you are asked to do summative marking, please contact the DPS.

Rating Your GTA Experience

After completing a confirmed practical, you will see a "Rate Your GTA Experience" section when you check your allocations. You can:

- Give a star rating (1–5) for the practical
- Leave optional comments about your experience

Ratings are reviewed by the DPS and help us improve the GTA programme. Your feedback is valued.

How the Allocation Works

The allocation is designed to be fair to everyone:

- Students with fewer previous demonstrating hours get priority — this ensures opportunities are shared fairly
- Your preferences are respected - the system tries to give everyone their top choices
- Multiple rounds - everyone gets one slot before anyone gets a second
- Reserve allocation - 2 backup GTAs assigned per practical

This means you might not always get your first choice, but the system ensures fair distribution across all students.

Frequently Asked Questions

Q: Can I change my preferences after submitting?

A: Contact the DPS (t.southall@imperial.ac.uk) if you need to make changes.

Q: What if I'm not available for a practical I've been allocated?

A: Contact the DPS as soon as possible so they can reallocate the slot. Withdrawing without good reason may reduce your priority in future rounds.

Q: How many practicals can I be allocated?

A: The default maximum is 3 practicals per student, but this may vary. You can set your own maximum when submitting preferences.

Q: What's the course code for?

A: You'll need the course code when submitting your pay claim for GTA work. It's included in your reminder emails.

Q: I didn't receive a reminder email - what should I do?

A: Check your spam/junk folder. If it's not there, verify your email address is correct and contact the DPS.

Q: I am a mature student or will be on a field course during term — can I still be a GTA?

A: Potentially yes, in specific circumstances. The DPS will consider your situation, but any arrangement requires agreement from you, the relevant course director, and that it would not impact your degree. Contact the DPS to discuss.

Q: I am from a department outside Life Sciences - can I sign up?

A: No. Only PhD students registered in the Department of Life Sciences (DoLS) are eligible to GTA for departmental practicals.

Q: How do I rate my GTA experience?

A: Once your allocation status is "Confirmed", a rating section will appear when you check your allocations. Select the practical, give a star rating, and optionally add comments.

Q: Will I be paid for the advertised hours, even if the practical finishes early?

A: No. You are paid for the hours you actually work, not the advertised hours. If a practical finishes earlier than advertised, your pay will reflect the actual time worked.

Need Help?

Contact the Director of Postgraduate Studies:
Tony Southall — t.southall@imperial.ac.uk